

ETHICS QUIZ — KEY POINTS FROM ALL 3 ARTICLES

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ARTICLE 1: Trust & Safety — The Most Important Tech Job You've Never Heard Of

Source: New Scientist

WHAT IS TRUST & SAFETY?

- A hybrid role spanning security, privacy, UX design, brand management, and community moderation
- They protect users AND protect the business from bad actors (spammers, terrorists, harassers)
- When misinformation floods a platform, data gets leaked, harassment spirals, or fraud/revenge porn appears — T&S handles it all

THE X/TWITTER CASE STUDY — WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU GUT T&S

- Musk nearly eliminated the trust & safety team as one of his first moves
- Immediate result: spam, harassment, and misinformation flooded users' feeds
- Users lost trust in the brand
- Advertisers pulled out in droves — tanking revenue
- A cascading disaster: technical, reputational, AND financial
- KEY LESSON: Removing T&S doesn't just hurt users, it destroys the business model

THE YOUTUBE COUNTER-EXAMPLE — WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU INVEST IN T&S

- YouTube comments used to be an absolute cesspit — slurs, scams, incoherent abuse
- YouTube invested in improvements, including a simple pop-up asking users to confirm comments met community guidelines
- Result: comments became genuinely useful. Not perfect, but dramatically better
- Shows that even small T&S interventions can have outsized positive effects

ELECTION INTEGRITY

- T&S teams worked with researchers and election officials during US election cycles
- Took down misinformation about polling locations and times
- Ensured citizens knew when and where to vote

THE INVISIBILITY PROBLEM

- When T&S works well, nobody notices — nobody celebrates "I wasn't harassed today!"
- We just assume products will be safe
- This makes T&S teams easy targets for layoffs and budget cuts
- The cruel irony: the people who do the most essential work get the least recognition

THE JUST-WORLD FALLACY ⚠️ KEY CONCEPT

- A cognitive bias where we assume the world is fair and bad things happen to people who deserve it
- Applied to tech:
 - If someone gets harassed on X → "they must have provoked it" (not a platform design flaw)
 - If someone gets hacked → "they were careless with their password" (not a security failure)
- This bias blinds us to SYSTEMIC PROBLEMS — the exact ones T&S teams exist to fix
- We blame victims instead of recognising design failures

BOTTOM LINE: "We don't appreciate trust and safety when they work, but we absolutely miss them when they're gone."

ARTICLE 2: Key Functions and Roles in Trust & Safety

Source: Trust & Safety Professional Association (TSPA)

THE 12 CORE FUNCTIONS OF A T&S TEAM

1. CONTENT POLICY 📄

Decides what's allowed and what's not. Policies reflect company values, user expectations, and legal requirements. Brief senior leadership on situations.

2. CONTENT DESIGN & STRATEGY 🖋️

Write user-facing content — help centre articles, product warnings, education materials. Making the rules understandable.

3. DATA SCIENCE & ANALYTICS 📊

Quantify how much policy-violating content exists. Measure whether moderation works. Predict trends. Find creative ways to detect adversarial behaviour. Without them, you're flying blind.

4. ENGINEERING ⚙️

Build ML models to automate enforcement at scale. Create reporting tools (DMCA takedowns), review tools for moderators, maintain technical infrastructure.

5. LEGAL ⚖️

Handle law enforcement requests, regulatory bodies, government agencies. Advise product teams on legal risks BEFORE features launch.

6. LAW ENFORCEMENT RESPONSE & COMPLIANCE 🚓

Process actual requests from police/agencies. Handle urgent escalations. Coordinate real-world crisis response (e.g. someone in danger). Distinct from Legal.

7. OPERATIONS 🏢

The engine room. Day-to-day moderation, QA, training moderators, managing outsourced vendors, workflow management, crisis response. Closest to the actual content — generate frontline insights.

8. PRODUCT POLICY 🎯

Subset of Content Policy but product-specific. E.g. ads might have stricter nudity rules than the main platform. Add nuance per product vertical.

9. PRODUCT MANAGEMENT 📋

Drive overall strategy for tackling specific abuse areas. E.g. a "hate speech PM" owns the entire hate speech strategy and coordinates across all teams.

10. PUBLIC POLICY & COMMUNICATIONS 🌐

External-facing. Build relationships with NGOs, governments, regulators. Shape public opinion about the platform's safety efforts.

11. SALES & ADVERTISER SUPPORT 💰

Handle advertisers' concerns about brand appearing next to harmful content. Not traditionally T&S but crucial — this is where revenue damage hits (see X/Twitter example).

12. THREAT DISCOVERY & RESEARCH 🔍

Hunt networks of abuse, research bad actor behaviour, work with law enforcement on criminal or large-scale abuse **operations**.

KEY PATTERNS

- T&S is massively cross-functional — policy, engineering, data science, legal, operations, comms all working together
- Scale requires automation — ML models because human moderation alone can't keep up
- Both proactive AND reactive — threat research hunts problems before they surface; operations handles them when they do
- Business and ethics are intertwined — advertiser support proves safety failures = revenue failures
- Operations teams are the insight generators — closest to content, they predict problems and shape future direction

ARTICLE 3: How Google Addresses Explicit Deepfake Content in Search

Source: Google Blog

THE PROBLEM

- Generative AI has enabled a surge in fake sexually explicit images/videos of real people ("deepfakes")

- Distributed without consent — causes deep distress to victims
- A new category of harm created by new **technology**

GOOGLE'S RESPONSE — TWO APPROACHES

APPROACH 1: EASIER REMOVAL PROCESS

- People could already request removal of non-consensual fake explicit imagery from Search
- NEW: When someone successfully removes one image, Google now automatically:
 - Filters similar explicit results on related searches about that person
 - Scans for and removes duplicates across Search
- Victims don't have to play whack-a-mole — one removal triggers broader protection
- Same system already worked for other non-consensual imagery; now extended to **deepfakes**

APPROACH 2: SMARTER RANKING SYSTEMS

Three layers:

- a) Downrank explicit fake content broadly — reduced exposure by OVER 70% on relevant queries
- b) Surface quality content instead — searches with people's names + explicit terms now show news articles about the issue, not actual deepfakes
- c) Penalise repeat-offender sites — if a site has many pages removed, Google demotes the ENTIRE site in **rankings**

THE NUANCE

- Technical challenge: distinguishing real consensual content (e.g. actor's nude scenes) from fake non-consensual content (deepfakes of that actor)
- Google acknowledges this is hard and **ongoing**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Technology creates new harms — generative AI enabled an entirely new abuse category
- Scalable solutions matter — one removal triggering automatic protection shows how T&S must work at scale
- Ranking IS moderation — you don't have to delete content to reduce harm; pushing it down is equally powerful
- 70% reduction — concrete metric proving interventions work
- Site-level penalties — systemic approach: punish platforms hosting harmful content, not just individual pieces
- Industry-wide problem — Google says this goes beyond search engines; needs cross-industry collaboration
- Victim-centred design — updates developed with feedback from experts AND victim-survivors

CROSS-ARTICLE THEMES FOR THE QUIZ

1. T&S IS ESSENTIAL BUT INVISIBLE — Success means nothing bad happens, which nobody notices. The just-world fallacy makes us blame victims instead of systems.
2. REMOVING T&S = DISASTER — X/Twitter is the definitive case study. Advertisers flee, users flee, revenue collapses.
3. INVESTING IN T&S WORKS — YouTube comments improved. Google reduced deepfake exposure by 70%. Small interventions, big impact.
4. SCALE REQUIRES AUTOMATION — ML models, automated duplicate detection, ranking systems. Humans alone can't moderate at internet scale.
5. BUSINESS AND ETHICS ARE INSEPARABLE — Advertiser concerns (TSPA), revenue collapse (X/Twitter), and brand trust all prove that safety IS the business model.
6. NEW TECHNOLOGY = NEW HARMS — Generative AI created deepfakes. Every tech advancement needs a corresponding T&S response.
7. CROSS-FUNCTIONAL BY NATURE — T&S needs policy, engineering, data science, legal, operations, comms. No single discipline can do it alone.
8. PROACTIVE > REACTIVE — Threat research, ranking systems, and automated scanning prevent harm before it reaches users. Better than cleaning up after.